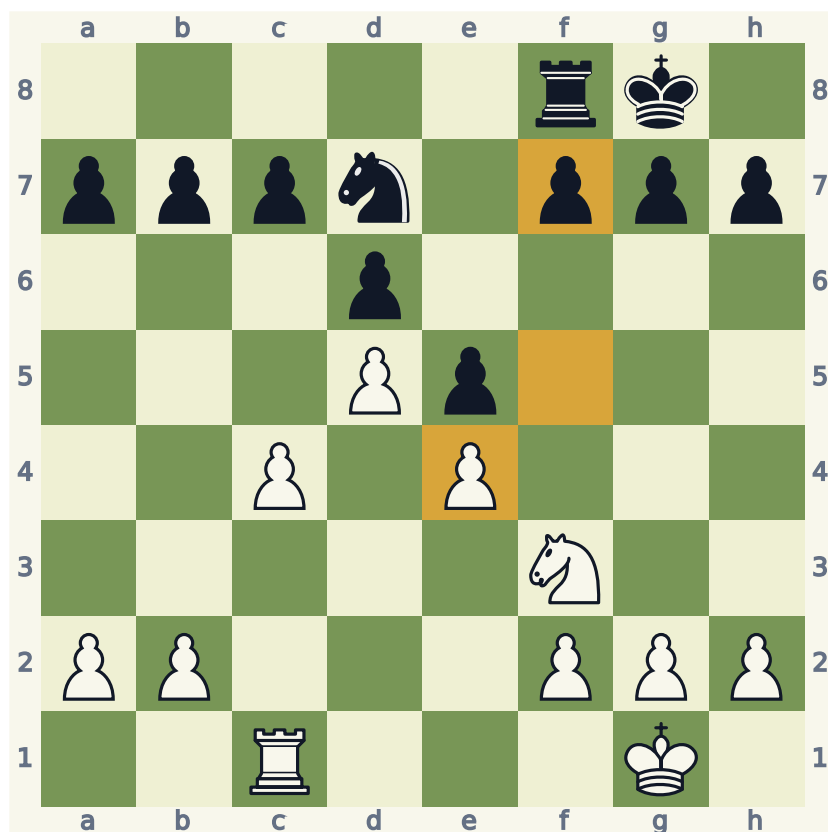


Prophylaxis and counterplay

Understand the opponent's useful move.

Prophylaxis means anticipating and limiting the opponent's plans. Ask what they would like to do if given a free move, then look for a move that improves your position while reducing that option. Prevention should have a specific target and should not cost more than the threat it stops.

MODEL A | WHITE TO MOVE



READ THE POSITION

- Black wants the freeing break ...f5 against e4.
- g3 gives the king air but does not stop ...f5.
- A move can look careful while failing to address the real plan.

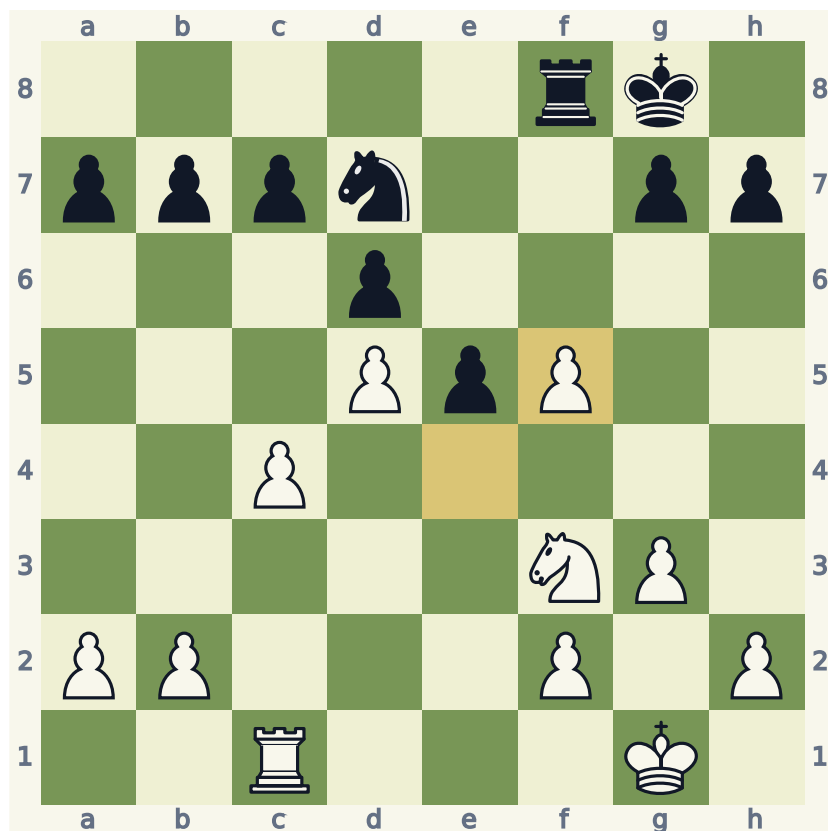
REMEMBER

- Name the opponent's intended move.
- Prefer prevention that also improves a piece.
- Recheck the cost and the alternative plan.

Follow the logic

1. g3 f5 2. exf5

MODEL A | POSITION AFTER THE LINE



g3?

This is a strategically unfocused candidate, not an asserted losing move. It changes the shelter without preventing Black's central break.

...f5

Black gets the intended contact with e4. White now has to calculate central changes.

exf5

White can capture, but the center has been transformed on Black's terms. Black may answer with the rook from f8, gaining activity.

THE OPPONENT'S PLAN

White should compare moves that restrain ...f5, prepare a favorable response to it, or create a stronger threat. Prevention is only one method; sometimes allowing the break and exploiting its cost is better.

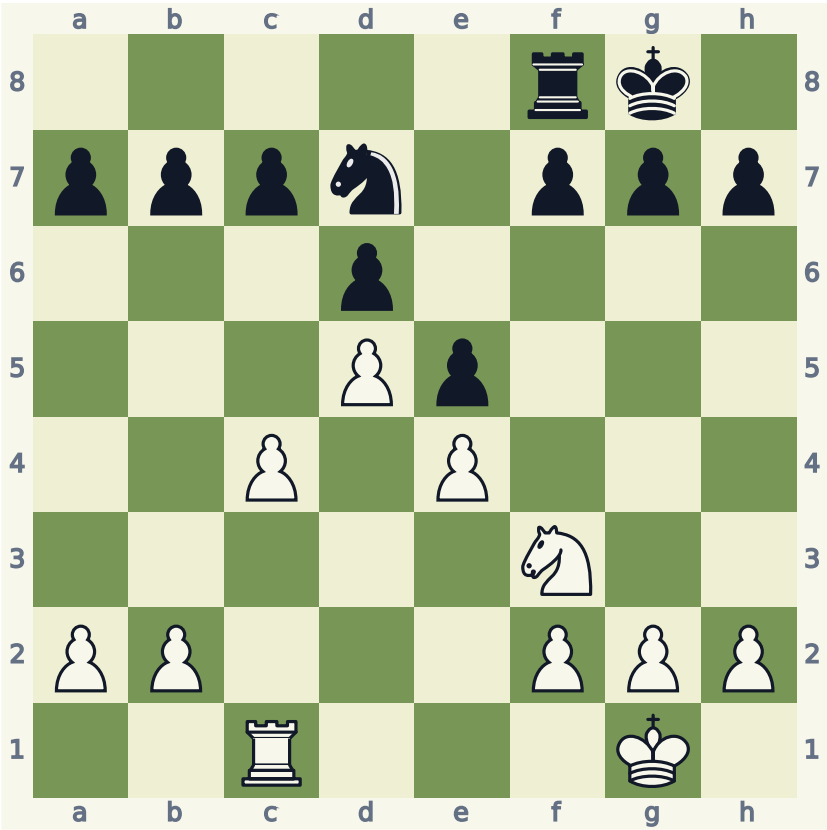
WHEN THE IDEA FAILS

Do not make a weakening pawn move merely because it stops one idea. Check whether the opponent can switch plans and attack the new weakness. Prophylaxis is active reasoning, not habitual caution.

Find the plan

Set a timer for 6 minutes. Write the reasons, not just a move.

EXERCISE B | WHITE TO MOVE



- 1. Which black advance does g4 discourage?
- 2. What structural price does White pay?
- 3. What should Black investigate instead of insisting on ...f5?

CHANGE ONE FEATURE

If allowing ...f5 gave you a forced tactical win, would you prevent it?

YOUR PLAN, THE OPPONENT'S REPLY, AND THE RESULTING POSITION

Position code (FEN): 5rk1/pppn1ppp/3p4/3Pp3/2P1P3/5N2/PP3PPP/2R3K1 w - - 0 1

Answers and transfer

1. The pawn on g4 controls f5. If Black plays ...f5, White can consider gxf5. That makes the freeing move less convenient, but concrete tactics can still matter.
2. White has advanced a king-shelter pawn and weakened squares such as f3 and h3. With queens on the board the price might be much greater. g4 is a candidate demonstrating a tradeoff, not a universal recommendation.
3. Black can consider ...c6 against d5, ...h5 against g4, or piece activity. Good prophylaxis anticipates a plan switch; stopping one break does not freeze the opponent.

ONE ILLUSTRATIVE LEGAL LINE

1. g4 h6

Changed feature: No. Let the opponent make the unfavorable break. The purpose is to improve your practical position, not to stop every move the opponent wants to play.

APPLY IT TO YOUR GAMES

Before each move in a slow practice game, write the opponent's most useful next move. Compare your prediction with what actually happens.

Self-check: Award 0-2 points per numbered answer: 1 for the relevant fact, 1 for its consequence. Add 2 for the changed-feature answer. Revisit the lesson at 5/8 or below; repeat from memory tomorrow and one week later.

Related topics: 04, 05, 21. | Reference links and notation key: 00_Start_Here.pdf.